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Ecology and culture of the pastoral Tuareg

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The drum-group (*e-bebel*) was the most important political unit among the Ahaggar Tuareg. The federation (*tégehé*) was for long periods split into quarrelling drum-groups. We have seen that quarrels might occur even within a drum-group which nevertheless remained a stable unit.

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It seems as if the stability of a drum-group was partly maintained by means of a joking relationship (*tehan-e-it*) between people of different classes. However, within the *Kel-e-la* drum-group there were tribes the members of which did not engage much in joking of this kind, and this was and is true notably of the *Dag-ali* tribe which is considered one of the oldest vassal tribes in Ahaggar. People of the *Dag-ali* to-day have no joking relationships with anyone beyond cross-cousins and brothers and sisters-in-law (cf. p. 454 f., 465 ff.). Most other tribes within the *Kel-e-la* drum-group joke with the tribes of the *Ise-emaren* class. The word "*Ise-emaren*" means literally "people who lie down upon the elbow supporting their head against the hand." People of this particular class is considered a kind of superior vassals because they are attached to no other noble Tuareg but their drum-chief. But nowadays, as in the past, they are spoken of disparagingly by both noble Tuareg and true vassals, who say that the *Ise-emaren* in the past did not engage in warfare and raiding expeditions, and that these Tuareg are on the whole very weak. Most noble Tuareg and vassals will joke with the *Ise-emaren*, and there is a particular strong joking relationship between the vassal tribe *Aguh-en-tehlé* and the *Ise-emaren* tribes. Such joking relationships are functionally related to joking relationships between relatives and in-laws and a fixed gift-exchange is observed between *Aguh-en-tehlé* Tuareg and *Ise-emaren* Tuareg when they visit each other. When the *Aguh-en-tehlé* Tuareg come to the *Ise-emaren* they

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must receive dates, while meat must be given to the *Iseɛmaren* visiting the *Aguh-en-tehlé*. The *Aguh-en-tehlé* tribe has the most intense joking relationship to the noble *Kel ɛela* Tuareg of all vassals. These vassals and the noble *Kel ɛela* engage in shamfights (*tebbillant*) exactly in the same way as cross-cousins. This intense joking relationship between the *Kel ɛela* and the vassal *Aguh-en-tehlé* should probably be explained in the light of the fact that the latter tribe was incorporated into the *Kel ɛela* drum-group more recently than most other vassals.

The different Tuareg classes do not generally intermarry. There are very few marriages between *Iseɛmaren* and *Kel Ulli* vassals, though love-making between them is common and facilitated by their mutual joking relationship. This is true particularly for certain *Iseɛmaren* tribes (*Iheyawen Hada*, *Kel Taɛulet*) and the *Aguh-en-tehlé* tribe. Wedding feasts in these *Iseɛmaren* tribes are most popular with young men of the *Aguh-en-tehlé* who are free to make love to the *Iseɛmaren* girls. Between noble Tuareg and vassals of the *Kel ɛela* drum-group there were in the past very few marriages, if any, while this was not so in the *Taytoɛ* drum-group, where marriages were contracted between 403 noble Tuareg and vassals. It would seem as if these mixed marriages had a political function as they served to reinforce the solidarity within the drum-group in view of its opposition to the *Kel ɛela* drum-group and the *Amenukal*. In consequence of these marriages the political relations between noble Tuareg and vassals of the *Taytoɛ* drum-group was in the past much influenced by rules of kinship behaviour, and the payments due to the drum-chief from vassals were less comprehensive than in the *Kel ɛela* drum-group.

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